from that era, for example the Apocalypse of Peter, the Apocalypse of James and even the Apocalypse of Abraham.[42] As for the life and teachings of Jesus, in addition to the four Gospels of Matthew, Mark, Luke and John, early Christians had the Gospel of Peter, the Gospel of Mary, the Gospel of Truth, the Gospel of the Saviour and numerous others.[43] Similarly, aside from the Acts of the Apostles, there were at least a dozen other Acts such as the Acts of Peter and the Acts of Andrew.[44] Letters were even more prolific. Most present-day Christian Bibles contain fourteen epistles attributed to Paul, three attributed to John, two to Peter, and one each to James and Jude. Ancient Christians were familiar not only with additional Pauline letters (such as the Epistle to the Laodiceans) but with numerous other epistles supposedly written by other disciples and saints.[45]

As Christians composed more and more gospels, epistles, prophecies, parables, prayers and other texts, it became harder to know which ones to pay attention to. Christians needed a curation institution. That's how the New Testament was created. At roughly the same time that debates among Jewish rabbis were producing the Mishnah and Talmud, debates among Christian priests, bishops and theologians were producing the New Testament.

In a letter from 367 CE, Bishop Athanasius of Alexandria recommended twenty-seven texts that faithful Christians should read – a rather eclectic collection of stories, letters and prophecies written by different people in different times and places. Athanasius recommended the Apocalypse of John, but not that of Peter or Abraham. He approved of Paul's Epistle to the Galatians, but not of Paul's Epistle to the Laodiceans. He endorsed the Gospels of Matthew, Mark, Luke and John, but rejected the Gospel of Thomas and the Gospel of Truth.[46]

A generation later, in the Councils of Hippo (393) and Carthage (397), gatherings of bishops and theologians formally canonised this list of recommendations, which became known as the New Testament.[47] When Christians talk about 'the Bible', they mean the Old Testament together with the New Testament. In contrast, Judaism never accepted the New Testament, and when Jews talk about 'the Bible', they mean only the Old Testament, which is supplemented by the Mishnah and Talmud. Interestingly, Hebrew to this day lacks a word to describe the Christian holy book, which contains both the Old Testament and the New Testament.